took a whole new meaning for me. Courage has always been a virtue I hold in the highest regard. A man or a woman with courage is the only one who can truly change this world.

Large sections of mainstream Indian media initially decided to black out the Yatra coverage, but given its tectonic impact on our politics, it could no longer be ignored. However, unfortunately, the many times the Yatra sparked full-fledged television debates and led to grand coverage were not for the sincerity of its message but for the unnecessary controversies our opponents generated around it. Like always, the BJP's IT cell worked overtime to unleash an unprecedented disinformation campaign that weaponized fake news with the sole intention of defaming Rahul ji. Yarns were even spun around Rahul ji's decision to not wear woollens or trim his beard! Our team aggressively called out and busted fake news in real time, and focused on conveying the message of the Yatra in its truest form—that love conquers hate. But it taught me an important life lesson—any lie, no matter how powerfully told, has a shelf life and the truth cannot be concealed forever. Our opponents did their best to assassinate Rahul ji's reputation, but the Yatra decisively demolished the smear campaign.

All through the course of the Bharat Jodo Yatra, our country's majestic diversity was on display, be it different languages, clothes, dances, customs or food (the Yatra was also a culinary tour across the nation, a delightful treat for the palate). India's radiant plurality opened her homes, streets, cities and hearts to Rahul Gandhi.

No mention of the Bharat Jodo Yatra can be complete without talking about its culmination in Kashmir. I distinctly remember 30 January 2023, the Yatra's snow-capped finale.

Standing under an open sky at the Sher-e-Kashmir stadium in Srinagar, Rahul Gandhi spoke for a little over thirty-six minutes, delivering the most iconic speech I have ever heard. Wearing a pheran, an outfit that Kashmiri men wear in extreme cold temperatures, and caressed by slowly falling snowflakes that covered his untamed hair and uncut beard of over five months (a subject of national television debates), he shared a moving account of his losses at the hands of violence and hate. From being told as a